In July 2020, I visited the Deendayal Upadhyaya Research Library, managed by the Sangh-affiliated Deendayal Dham in the late Jan Sangh's leader's hometown of Mathura. The Coronavirus lockdown had not yet been lifted and the sprawling Deendayal Dham complex —which includes a large school (Saraswati Shishu Mandir), a student hostel (Bhaurau Deoras Hostel), a large rural employment self-help centre and an Ayurvedic pharmacy selling cow-based products (Kamdhenu Gaushala Pharmacy)—was largely deserted. As I perused the archival shelves for the rare Sangh literature I had gone to find, I got into a conversation with two teenaged schoolboys. They were the only other people in the library, and had been engrossed in deep study when we reached. Surrounded by writing papers, both boys were feverishly scribbling notes from the competition books they were studying. Both also had installed in front of them their mobile phones, set on small portable stands and connected to earphones. They seemed to be simultaneously listening to a video and writing notes, while constantly also consulting the books in front of them. Impressed by their discipline, I asked what examination they were studying for. National Defence Academy, they both responded enthusiastically. They were students from the Saraswati Shishu Mandir and did not want to lose time preparing for their entrance examination, I discovered. As I got back to my own reading, I realised that the archival library shelves, near which we were all sitting, occupied only half the floor. The other half served as a traditional RSS altar of veneration, carefully adorned with images of the Sangh's pantheon of reverence: the customary photo of Bharat Mata, which has pride of place in every RSS and BJP office; the Om symbol; portraits of the Sangh's first two sarsanghchalaks, Dr Hedgewar and Guru Golwalkar; a large saffron banner depicting the Ram Temple in Ayodhya and the original version of Sangh Pratigya (pledge) that every swayamsevak takes. The pledge on the wall read:

I hereby, remembering the Almighty and my ancestor, take the pledge that I have become a member of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh to protect the sacred Hindu Dharma, Hindu Sanskriti and Hindu society and to make this Hindu Rashtra